

REDUCING FLOW OF INDUS WATERS

India has already suspended the Indus Waters Treaty that apportions the rivers of the Indus system among the two countries. While this wouldn't immediately affect Pakistan, if India does disrupt or divert the flow of water by building canals or dams, lower riparian regions in Pakistan's Punjab and Sindh would be seriously affected.

Fallout: Pakistan has declared that any attempt to divert Indus waters would be "an act of war".

SURGICAL STRIKES

The Indian army's special forces or commando units can cross the LoC, attack Jaish-e-Mohammed/ Lashkar-e-Toiba terror camps . This is exactly what happened after the Uri attack in September 2016, when Indian commandos conducted a series of strikes and claimed that they had taken out 150-odd terrorists.

Fallout: Once bitten already, Pakistan army units along the border will be on high alert to such an eventuality. A surgical strike could actually be employed in conjunction with an air attack on the terror infrastructure.



DIPLOMATIC PRESSURE



Pakistan, with its long, dubious record in harbouring terror groups, has spent three periods in the 'grey list' of the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), the global watchdog on terror financing and money laundering, the latest being 2018-22. Pakistan is surviving on IMF loans, so another spell on the FATF list would be calamitous.

Fallout: After Pahalgam, India has the support of all major countries; our diplomats are briefing them too. Pakistan has reason to expect a diplomatic blitzkrieg. Another option is to paralyse their economy by enforcing a blockade by the Indian Navy on its ports. But that would be considered an act of extreme hostility, akin to declaration of war.

PAKISTAN'S ACTION WAS PROMPTED AS MUCH BY ITS OWN POLYCRISIS AS BY THE NEED TO TELL INDIA AND THE WORLD THAT IT WAS STILL A STAKEHOLDER IN KASHMIR

"We must be clear whether we are messaging Pakistan or the world about our capability. We upped the ante in Uri with surgical strikes and in Balakot with air strikes. Do we do both this time but confine it to terrorist hideouts as we did in the past, or do we expand the ambit and target the Pakistan army directly, which would amount to war? So, it is a question of calibration and what you want to achieve in the end."

THE TURMOIL IN PAKISTAN

To calibrate and control the escalation ladder in response to such a strike, India must first understand Pakistan's internal dynamics, say experts. Especially what prompted it to launch such a major terror attack and the targets it chose, knowing India would retaliate. According to Sharat Sabharwal, a former high commissioner to Pakistan, the timing of the attack could not have been more strategic—US Vice President J.D. Vance was in India and Modi was on a bilateral visit to Saudi Arabia. An audacious attack was certain to grab worldwide attention and signal that Pakistan cannot be ignored. The other reason, Sabharwal believes, was to shatter the sense of normalcy ushered in first by the abrogation of Article 370 in 2019 and then the recent assembly election in Jammu and Kashmir. It was most evident in the return of tourists to the region, with J&K attracting 23 million visitors last year compared to 17 million in 2018. By targeting tourists